PHOTOGRAPHS BY RICHARD RAFFAN

Get set to turn

Richard Raffan gives guidance on kit to start turning

RICHARD RAFFAN

Richard Raffan is a highly respected and well known woodturner and is best known for his turned bowls and boxes. He is a teacher, demonstrator and author of a number of classic woodturning books and DVDs.

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Throughout my 35 years of teaching I've encountered a lot of novice woodturners who nearly abandoned the craft thinking they'd never get the hang of it, when in fact their problem was not so much with themselves but their lathe and the way it was set up, and the tools they were using. And that's before we get to how they were using the tools.

You can purchase the cheapest new motor vehicle secure in the knowledge that it'll get you from A to B in the dry and at a reasonable speed. It might not be as comfortable as the 12-litre supercharged midlife crisis you'd like, but it will do the job – unlike a cheap lathe. Cheap lathes are a total waste of money, never living up to expectations raised by images on the box of large bowls, long spindles or tabletops. Such images are optimistic to fraudulent as many of these very cheap lathes are barely up to even basic spindle turning, let alone anything else. So here's some advice on what you need to get into woodturning and how to set up a lathe.

Choosing a lathe

Many embryo turners try not to spend too much on their first lathe in case they don't like the craft. Back in 1970 that was me who, despite advice that I'd be wasting my money, purchased a Coronet Major with a saw-bench and sander accessories. Within a couple of weeks I realised my error and ordered a new Harrison Graduate Short Bed. It took three months to arrive, but was worth the wait.

I was seduced into buying the Coronet by an image on the brochure of a guy in a shop-coat purportedly turning a tabletop 4ft diameter. As an aspiring professional turner I'd been thinking in terms of small boxes, but suddenly tables seemed a good idea too. The Coronet was adequate for centrework, but the bearings couldn't cope with the strain of turning bowls, endgrain hollowing, or my ineptitude. I went through three lots of bearings in as many months and broke several rests and faceplates.

The Harrison Graduate introduced me to the joys of a decent lathe, and I have never looked back. I used it hard for 25 years and never needed to replace the bearings, motor or rests. Twenty-five years later I sold it cheap for six times what I paid for it. Second-rate lathes are unlikely to hold their value like that. A good lathe won't lose value and if you don't take to the craft you'll likely sell it for at least what you gave for it. Names to look for include Jet, Vicmarc, Powermatic, Robust, Steinert, Laguna, Record, Axminster, Oneway and many more. But do your research before you buy.

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